

Pastures, seeding and fertiliser



Special feature

Dargo proves itself in the field

Dargo diploid annual ryegrass has proven, yet again, its potential to produce high dry matter yields in WA's environment, especially through the early winter and spring periods.

Dargo achieved an average yield of 112 per cent of the mean on the winter early spring cuts in the 2009 annual ryegrass trials conducted at Waroona.

Its ability to establish with high tiller numbers early means Dargo produces a high level of production through the first two grazings.

Dargo has been successfully grown in WA for several years in increasing quantities, reflecting its consistently high yields across a range of environments and farming systems.

It can be sown in a wide range of soils types in areas that have 400mm of annual winter based rainfall, making it more tolerant of dryer conditions than other similar annual ryegrass options (see box, far left).

To optimise the yields from Dargo, there are several recommendations (see box, below).

By adopting a rotational grazing system and sound fertiliser management practices, Dargo can consistently produce high yields of dry matter over the growing period.

This has the potential to provide significant income over and above the production normally achieved from a Wimmera-based pasture.

■ For more information, contact Irwin Hunter & Co. on (08) 9383 4708 or visit: www.irwinhunter.com.au



Don Lidgerwood and Alan Gowers inspecting Dargo diploid annual ryegrass.

Attributes

Dargo diploid annual ryegrass has the following attributes:

- Excellent early establishment vigour;
- Excellent winter and spring production;
- High quality forage throughout the growing season;
- High production where good fertiliser practices are adopted;
- Is very responsive to nitrogen applications;
- Has a high tolerance to leaf rust; and
- Suited to grazing, silage and hay.

Dargo diploid annual ryegrass recommended sowing rate:

Minimum of 20kg and up to 30kg per hectare in rainfall zones above 500mm, plus accompanying clovers. (Increased sowing rates will increase pasture production where supported with increased fertiliser and rainfall.) In lower rainfall zones of 400-500mm, 10kg/ha is sufficient.



Dargo diploid annual ryegrass crop showing the height and quality forage for cutting.

Optimising yields

To optimise the yields from Dargo diploid annual ryegrass, the following recommendations will provide a guide applicable to a range of situations:

- Ensure there is adequate moisture to initiate germination and support the plant through the early stages of growth;
- Ensure adequate phosphorus, potassium, sulphur and fertiliser is applied at the time of sowing to support the estimated production over winter;
- To improve tiller density lightly graze at 6-8cm high or when the plant cannot be easily pulled out by grazing animals;
- Continue to graze on a rotational basis throughout the balance of the winter and spring grazing at between 10cm and 15cm high;
- Apply up to 25 units of urea after the first and subsequent grazings prior to shutting up for hay; and
- If shutting up for silage, haylage or hay, apply the required fertiliser to balance the potential nutrient loss from the respective crop.

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